PSCI 3350.001 Comparative Politics

Lecture 5: Social structure and politics

Karl Ho

THE UNIVERSITY OF TEXAS AT DALLAS
School of Economic, Political and Policy Sciences

Today's puzzle

> Who participates, and who is represented — and does the way a society is *organized* explain democracy independently of its history, economics and culture?

Chapter 5 was held back until now on purpose. The background chapters gave you history, economics and culture. This one adds **social structure**, and it bears directly on the question of representation that the institutional chapters have been circling.

Learning goals

By the end of class you should be able to:

1. Explain what **cross-cutting cleavages** are and why pluralists think they help democracy
2. State the case that feudalism **helped** democracy and the case that it **hurt** it — and Moore's way of resolving them
3. Give **Dahl's two mechanisms** linking extreme inequality to dictatorship
4. Define **civil society**, and say what it excludes
5. Distinguish Almond's **four types of interest group**
6. Explain **social capital** and Putnam's four causes of civic decline
7. Separate **Civil Society I, II and III**, and state the endogeneity problem that hangs over all three

Part 1: Social structure and pluralism

The chapter's spine

SOCIAL STRUCTURE
"the way in which society is organized" — hierarchical, as in caste systems, or egalitarian

THE CHAPTER LIMITS ITSELF TO THREE ISSUES

Feudalism 1

Does a feudal past help democracy, or block it?

Moore: the English lords commercialized, and became a bourgeoisie.

Tocqueville: the US had no feudal hierarchy to escape.

Inequality 2

Do gaps between rich and poor undermine democracy?

Aristotle, Mill, Lipset: a large middle class sustains it.

Dahl: concentrated wealth blocks reform from above and breeds resentment below.

Civil society 3

Does associational life build democracy — or follow it?

Tocqueville, Almond and Verba, Putnam: it builds it.

Foley and Edwards: the effects depend on democracy and a strong state already existing.

Figure 1: Social structure, and the three issues Chapter 5 limits itself to. Click to enlarge.

The claim

The structure of societies shapes the kinds of political systems that emerge — **independent of** political culture and economics.

- **Marx**: conflict between groups, especially classes, is the prime determinant of the political system that emerges — though those conflicts were primarily economic
- **Huntington (1984)**: democracy is facilitated by a widely differentiated and articulated social structure with relatively autonomous social classes, regional groups, occupational groups, and ethnic and religious groups

The **pluralist** version: what best promotes democracy is a large number of relatively autonomous **associational groups** — independent of the state, and a

Why pluralism is supposed to work

Cross-cutting cleavages	People of different races, ethnicities or classes find themselves sharing recreational interests or bound together in a union. Those ties *cut across* social, ethnic, racial and religious differences, promoting tolerance and acceptance
Limiting state power	Autonomous groups let society control the state — and democratic institutions are the most effective means of exercising that control

And the contrapositive, which is the claim that actually does the work: societies **without** such autonomous groups are far more likely to be dominated by **a centralized state, or an authoritarian or totalitarian dictatorship**.

Note: what makes a cleavage cross-cutting?

A cross-cutting cleavage is one where:

- The cleavage is politically irrelevant and therefore harmless
- Every major social division separates the same people into the same two camps
- The groups involved are too small to affect national politics
- Membership in one group cuts across membership in another, so people who differ on one divide share another

Shared membership across divides. **The second option describes *reinforcing* cleavages** — which is Chapter 4's polarization arriving under a different name.

Part 2: Feudalism

Feudalism cuts both ways

Feudalism helped	An early form of pluralism that limited the development of centralized state power — so such systems were likelier to evolve into democracies than those lacking that social pluralism. The record of Western Europe against Russia, and Japan against China, suggests something to it (Moore, from Chapter 2)
Feudalism hurt	**Tocqueville**: the *absence* of feudalism helped democracy in the United States, because there were no embedded hierarchies preventing social and political mobility. The persistence of feudalism in Latin America is held up as the counter-example

The resolution: the question is not whether feudalism existed but **what kind** existed. For **Moore (1966)**, English democracy turned on the transformation — the **commercialization** — of the English feudal lords, who became the basis of the bourgeoisie. Not so elsewhere, and certainly not in Latin America.

"No bourgeois, no democracy"

> Moore's own restatement of the proposition, in its more limited formulation.

So the key to democracy is a **large indigenous bourgeoisie** — which ties the economic system, the social structure and the political system into one chain.

Why a market economy supplies the social base (Lipset 1961):

1. A market economy requires a **dispersion of economic power** and some form of private property — and dispersed economic power creates alternative centres of political power that check the state
2. Market economies are likelier to produce **sustained growth** than command economies — and wealth creates the desire for wealth protection, which gives rise to social organizations

Note: what does Moore's formula mean?

Moore's "No bourgeois, no democracy" claims that democracy requires:

- A large indigenous commercial middle class, which in England grew out of the commercialization of the feudal lords
- An urban industrial working class organized into parties
- The absence of a feudal past
- A market economy, regardless of which classes it produces

A large indigenous bourgeoisie. **The English lords became that class**; elsewhere — Latin America above all — feudal elites stayed feudal, and no such class appeared.

Part 3: Inequality

Inequality and democracy

Since **Aristotle**, the argument has run in both directions: by reducing inequalities in the distribution of *political power*, democracy helps reduce inequalities of *wealth and status* (see also Mill 1862).

Running the other way: **extreme inequalities in wealth undermine democratic political structures**. Aristotle pointed to the importance of a large middle class — a sentiment echoed much later by **Lipset (1959)**.

Dahl (1971, ch. 6) gives two mechanisms by which extreme inequality produces dictatorship.

Dahl's two mechanisms

From above	Concentrated economic resources make the "haves" unwilling to accept reform or extend rights to the "have nots," believing the have nots will deprive them of their wealth. Concentrated wealth in a few hands undermines meaningful democracy
From below	Inequality produces high resentment among the "have nots" — likely to translate into violence, or at minimum to undermine the legitimacy democracies depend on

And the asymmetry that makes it a regime question: an authoritarian government **can repress** reactions against inequality; **a democracy cannot indefinitely repress and remain democratic**.

> "The effect of inequality on democracy is anticipated because concentrated economic rewards lead to similarly concentrated political resources, undermining political equality. And economic inequality generates frustrations that undermine allegiance to democratic procedures."
>
> Bollen and Jackman 1985, p. 440

Note: Dahl's asymmetry

Why, on Dahl's account, does extreme inequality threaten democracies more than it threatens dictatorships?

- Dictatorships usually have less inequality to begin with
- A dictatorship can repress the reaction to inequality; a democracy cannot repress indefinitely and remain a democracy
- Inequality is harder to measure in democracies, so the effect is overstated
- Democracies redistribute, which provokes the wealthy into mounting coups

The repression asymmetry. **Both regime types face the resentment; only one can suppress it without ceasing to be itself**.

Part 4: Civil society

What is civil society?

LSE Centre for Civil Society: an "arena of uncoerced collective action around shared interests, purposes and values. In theory, its institutional forms are distinct from those of the state, family and market, though in practice, the boundaries … are often complex, blurred and negotiated."

Diamond (1994): "the realm of organised social life that is voluntary, self generating, self supporting, autonomous from the state, and bound by the legal order or set of shared rules … citizens acting collectively in a public sphere to express their interests, passions, and ideas … make demands on the state, and hold state officials accountable. It is an intermediary entity, standing between the private sphere and the state."

What civil society is not

Civil society focuses on expressly **public and political** goods, not private ones. So the concept excludes:

- **Family life**
- **Inward-looking group activity**
- **The profit-making enterprise of individual firms** — organizations that pursue private gain

It is also distinct from **political society** — groups directly tied to the state: Congress, the bureaucracy, political parties. Civil society shapes political society, but **is conceptually distinct from it**.

Note: which of these is civil society?

On the chapter's definition, which belongs to **civil society**?

- An independent tenants' association lobbying the city on housing policy
- A political party contesting national elections
- A family-run firm pursuing profit
- A congressional caucus organized around a shared policy interest

The tenants' association. **Voluntary, autonomous from the state, pursuing a public good** — while the caucus and the party are *political* society, and the firm pursues private gain.

Three spheres



Figure 2: What the concept of civil society includes, and the two things on either side of it that it excludes. Click to enlarge.

An old idea

The concept long predates the 1990s revival.

Socrates	Truth is discovered through open public argument via the dialectic; public argument ensures civility in the body politic
Plato	A just society is one where people work for the common good and practice civic virtues — wisdom, moderation, justice
Aristotle (c. 335 BC)	Citizens must know each other's character and preferences to choose leaders well; the *polis* is an "association of associations" enabling citizens to share in ruling and being ruled
Cicero	*Societas civilis* — a good society ensuring peace and order among the population

But the classical notion **did not distinguish society from the state**. That separation waits for **the Treaty of Westphalia in 1648** and the sovereign state it recognized.

Hobbes and Locke: society gives life to the state

Westphalia let monarchs build central control — national armies, professional bureaucracies, absolutism outside England. Enlightenment thinkers responded.

Hobbes	A champion of absolutism seeking a *rational* basis for it. In the state of nature life is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish and short"; reason persuades people to surrender sovereignty to a common power. A civil society existed **prior to and apart from** the state, and its formation produced government, state and laws — which then sustained civility
Locke	Writing to justify replacing James II in 1688. The state of nature is unpleasant but not inevitably a state of war; people would leave it only for a *better* way to protect life, liberty and property — which an absolute monarch is not. Two treatises: people submit to a common authority, and that authority is limited and may not threaten basic rights

Both arrive at the same structural claim from opposite politics: **society gives life to the state**, and **the state is charged with protecting civil society**.

Tocqueville and Durkheim

Alexis de Tocqueville (1840) wrote at length on the necessity of civil associations for democracy.

- Americans joined voluntary organizations of all kinds, from social clubs to service organizations
- That rich associational life led to the blossoming of democracy in the new republic
- Associations let citizens **overcome their lack of influence as separate individuals**; as associations grew, the state and other actors were forced to notice and recognize their preferences

Durkheim ([1893] 1984): connections between individuals **remain after the initial interaction**. Those lasting ties shape the social capital that results, so associations persistently affect one another through the impact individuals make on

Almond's four interest groups

Twentieth-century political scientists identified civil society as made up of interest groups. **Almond (1958)** distinguishes four.

Built from Ishiyama ch. 5, after Almond (1958)

Type	Organization	Basis	Example
Anomic	Almost none — dissipates once the fury of the mob is spent	Spontaneous collective response to a frustration	Organized protest, riots
Non-associational	Generally unorganized; activity depends on the issue at hand	Common kinship or identity ties — race, ethnicity	—
Institutional	Mostly formal	Has some *other* political or social function besides the interest	Caucus groups in Congress; bureaucratic agencies
Associational	Highly organized — internal hierarchy, steady funds	Formed **explicitly** to represent a set of issues	Free trade unions, gun or animal rights groups, professional organizations

Associational groups are the ones that matter for democracy, and the feature that separates them from institutional groups is **independence from the state** — they influence its actions without being part of it.

Note: institutional or associational?

What distinguishes an **associational** interest group from an **institutional** one?

- Associational groups are bound together by kinship or ethnic identity
- Associational groups are larger and better funded
- Associational groups are formed spontaneously in response to a grievance
- Associational groups are independent of the state, rather than being part of it

Independence from the state. **Both types are highly organized and well funded** — which is exactly why the second option fails, and why the real line is structural, not a matter of size.

Civil society as a school for democracy

Almond and Verba (1963) — the same pair as Chapter 4 — argued voluntary associations were the most important mediating factor between individuals and the state.

Resources	Associating gives a person political resources usable toward their own goals
Attitudes	Membership shapes political attitudes; the political element of many organizations produces better awareness, better voting choices, more participation, more accountability
A check on authority	Associational groups monitor the state continually, subjecting leaders to popular scrutiny
Dense networks	Multiple channels to voice opinions and articulate interests give individuals a reason to engage
A school for democracy	Working together in the Boy Scouts, a union or a professional body teaches cooperation, teamwork and compromise — and supplies the main channels for leadership training and political recruitment

Putnam: social capital

Robert Putnam (1993, 1995): even **non-political** organizations are vital — bowling leagues, sporting clubs — because they build **social capital**, trust and shared values that transfer into the political sphere.

Physical capital	Machines, economic inputs — raises productivity
Human capital	An educated workforce — raises productivity
Social capital	*How a society is organized* — also raises productivity

What made the American economy and state strong was **dense social networks** producing norms of social trust that facilitated coordination and cooperation for mutual benefit — an echo of Tocqueville a century and a half later.

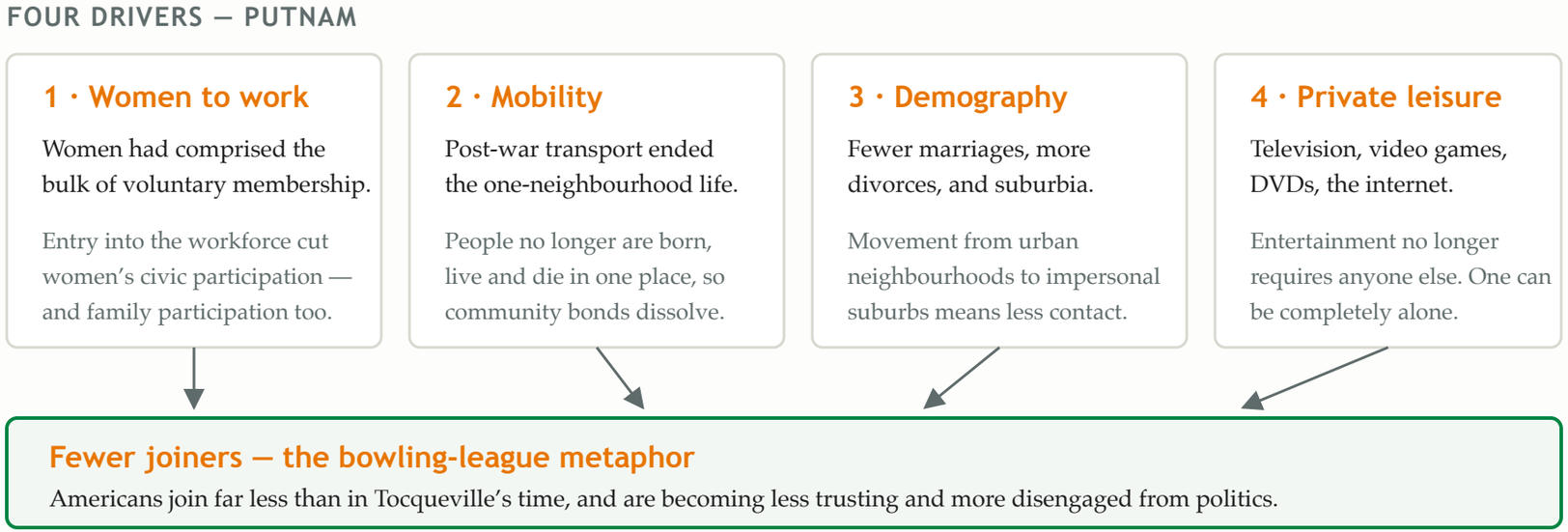
Why civil society declined

Putnam's metaphor is the decline of organized **bowling leagues**: Americans join far less than in Tocqueville's time, and are becoming less trusting and more disengaged.

1. **Movement of women into the labour force.** Women had comprised the bulk of voluntary organization membership; their entry into the workforce reduced women's civic participation and family participation overall
2. **Greater mobility.** Post-war transport ended the pattern of being born, living and dying in one neighbourhood — and with it the social bonds of identifiable communities
3. **Other demographic changes.** Fewer marriages, more divorces, and movement from urban neighbourhoods to impersonal suburbia
4. **Technological transformation and the privatization of leisure.** Television, video games, DVDs, the internet — one can be completely alone to be entertained

The implication: decline in civic engagement, and ultimately **in the health of democracy in the developed world**.

What the decline looks like



The implication Putnam draws: declining civic engagement, and ultimately a decline in the health of democracy in the developed world. Note that none of the four drivers is political — which is exactly the move the critics attack.

Figure 3: Putnam's four causes of civic decline, and what they add up to. Click to enlarge.

Note: Putnam's bowling leagues

Putnam uses bowling leagues as evidence for a claim about democracy because:

- Bowling league membership correlates with turnout across American states
- Leagues were among the few associations open to women before the 1970s
- Even non-political associations build social capital — trust and shared values — that transfers into the political sphere
- Bowling leagues were historically a recruiting ground for party activists

Even **non-political** groups build social capital. **That is the move that makes the argument interesting and the one that makes it vulnerable** — the critics' question is whether the transfer happens at all.

Part 5: The critique

Are dense networks a good thing?

Schattschneider (1960)	Interest groups are elite groups, motivated primarily by private interest rather than the public good
Olson (1965)	By the logic of collective action, small well-organized groups dominate the political process, leaving many voices unheard
Lowi (1969)	"Interest group liberalism" — groups pursuing progressive goals produce status quo conservatism, since they protect what they have once they achieve it

So interest group pluralism came under fire as **undemocratic**: the special interests it represents detract from democracy.

Nor is there any reason in principle why dense networks should make a democratic state *more efficient*. The "counterweight of civil society" may be a **burden** — dense webs of association that **leach off resources and threaten the smooth and equitable function of the modern state**.

Three civil societies

Foley and Edwards (1996) find two conceptions in the literature — potentially contradictory. **Booth and Richard (1998)** add a third.

Built from Ishiyama ch. 5, after Foley and Edwards (1996) and Booth and Richard (1998)

	Emphasis	Relation to the state
Civil Society I	Associational life fosters patterns of civility; a socializing and educating force promoting tolerance and cooperation	Positive effects of association **with** governance
Civil Society II	Civil society as a **counterweight** to the state — independent by definition, promoting accountability and checking tyranny	Separate **from** the state
Civil Society III	Voluntary associations that are revolutionary in nature, and do **not** promote democracy	Dense civic networks may turn separatist, centrifugal and divisive in weak or unstable systems — especially deeply ethnically divided ones

I and II contradict: one needs civil society **close to** the state to socialize good citizens, the other needs it **apart from** the state to check tyranny. **It cannot be defined as both at once**.

The contradiction, drawn

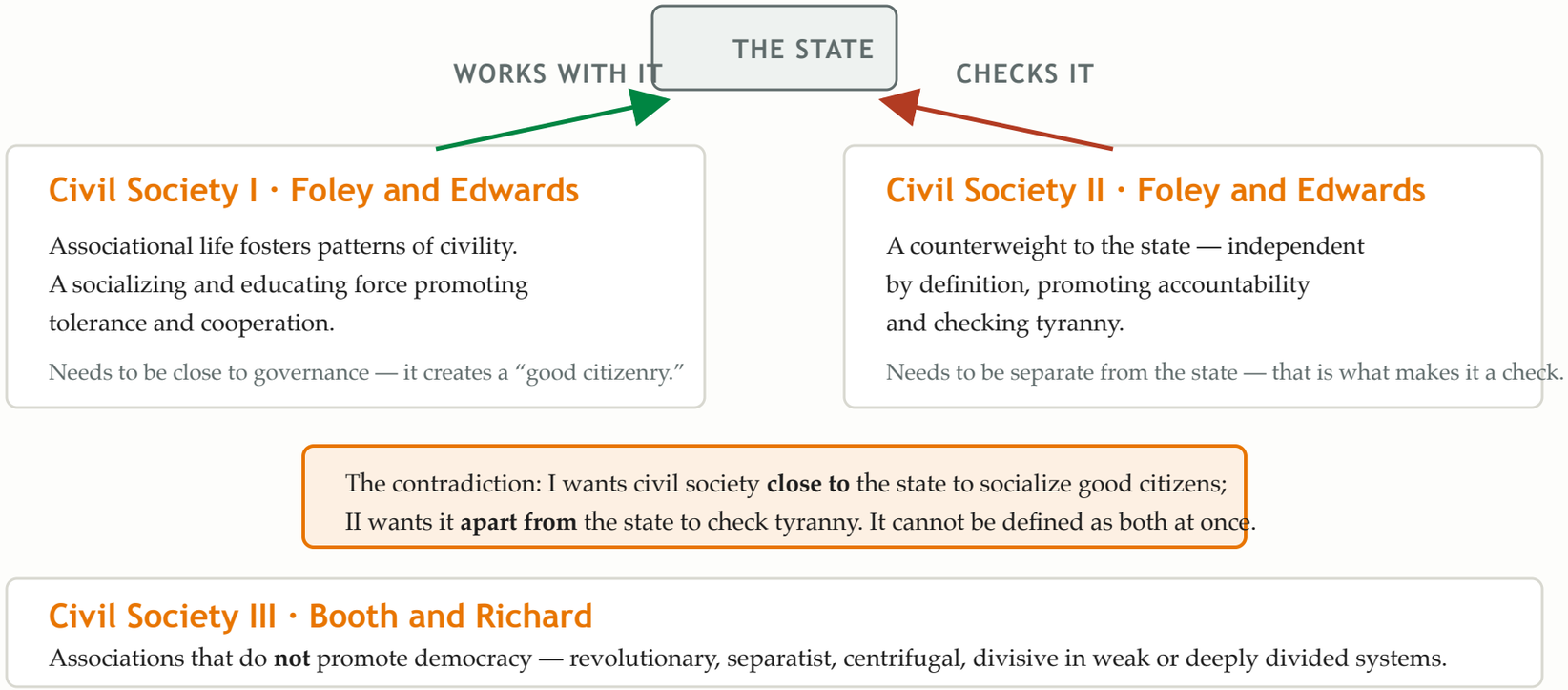


Figure 4: Civil Society I, II and III — and why the first two cannot both be right. Click to enlarge.

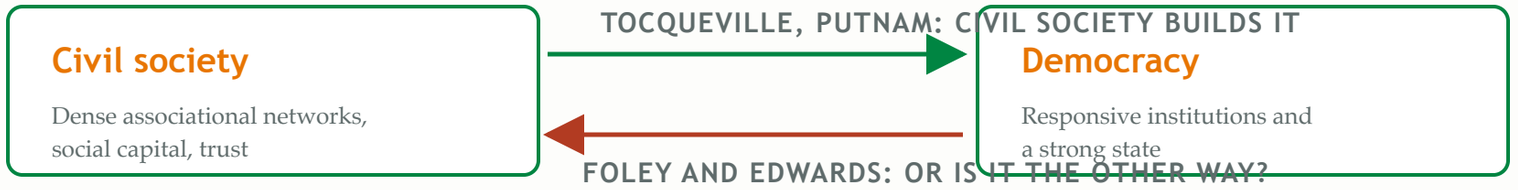
The endogeneity problem

> "The strength and responsiveness of a democracy may depend on the character of civil society, as Putnam argues, reinforcing both the democratic functioning and strength of the state. But such effects depend on the **prior achievement of both democracy and a strong state**."
>
> Foley and Edwards 1996, p. 281

Which caused which? Did civil society **cause** democracy in the West, as Tocqueville and Putnam suggest — or did a democratizing state **give rise to civil society**?

This is more than academic. Unless the relationship is understood, it is difficult to contend civil society causes anything at all — which calls into quest

Which way does the arrow run?



"The strength and responsiveness of a democracy may depend on the character of civil society, as Putnam argues … But such effects depend on the **prior achievement of both democracy and a strong state**."

Foley and Edwards 1996, p. 281

Why this is more than academic

Unless the direction is settled, it is hard to say civil society causes anything — which calls into question every civil-society-building progra

Figure 5: The endogeneity problem, and the policy that rests on it. Click to enlarge.

Two more criticisms

Overstated attachment	**Stolle and Hooghe (2003)**: the impact of social capital *outside* the group setting is weak, if it exists at all. They urge a focus on the internal workings of groups rather than pronouncements about civil society as a whole. **Foley and Edwards (1996)**: focusing on non-political organizations underestimates participation in explicitly political ones — and there is no necessary connection between civic engagement and political engagement
Measurement	How do you measure social capital? Surveys make cross-country comparison hard, since ideas do not transfer. Counting groups raises questions of which groups to include, how to distinguish types, and whether to include a time element. Social networks are hard to measure because the connections are intrinsically weak

Not insurmountable — but they must be considered **in evaluating what researchers conclude**.

Note: the strongest objection to Putnam

Which objection most directly threatens the **core** of Putnam's argument?

- Social capital is difficult to measure across countries
- There is no necessary connection between civic engagement and political engagement
- Dense networks can become separatist in divided societies
- Interest groups are elite-dominated and serve private interests

The missing link. Putnam's whole claim is that **non-political** association transfers into political life. **If the transfer does not happen, the bowling leagues explain nothing** — the others weaken the argument; this one removes its mechanism.

Where this leaves the argument

Ishiyama's summing up: little consensus on the effects of civil society on the *development* of democracy — but considerable agreement it has **some** effect.

What he does commit to:

- Where political cultures value **tolerance, moderation, compromise and civility**, democracy is easier to develop — and civil society helps promote those values
- Whether civil society promotes democracy or democracy promotes civil society is **not always clear**
- But there is consensus that civil society helps **maintain** democracy

Note the retreat in that last line. The strong claim was that civil society *builds*

Today's article: Clayton and Zetterberg

"Quota Shocks" — gender quotas as a shock to who gets represented, and what follows.

- A quota changes descriptive representation **by design and by a known date** — which is what makes it usable as an identification strategy rather than just a policy
- The question is what happens *downstream*: whether changing who sits in the legislature changes what the state spends on and does

Read it against this chapter. Ishiyama's social structure arrives through **voluntary association** — slow, self-generating, hard to engineer. A quota is the opposite: **representation altered by institutional fiat**, and therefore testable.